

NEWTON'S INTERPOLATION FORMULA AND SUMS OF POWERS

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ABSTRACT. In this manuscript, we derive formulas for multifold sums of powers by utilizing Newton's interpolation formula. Furthermore, we provide formulas for multifold sums of powers in terms of Stirling numbers of the second kind and Eulerian numbers.

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1. INTRODUCTION

2. AUXILIARY LEMMAS

For multifold sums of powers, we use the notation provided by Donald Knuth in [1], because it is simple and beautiful.

Definition 2.1 (Multifold sums of powers). *For non-negative integers r, n, m*

$$\Sigma^0 n^m = n^m,$$

$$\Sigma^1 n^m = \Sigma^0 1^m + \Sigma^0 2^m + \cdots + \Sigma^0 n^m,$$

$$\Sigma^{r+1} n^m = \Sigma^r 1^m + \Sigma^r 2^m + \cdots + \Sigma^r n^m.$$

We utilize the following notation for rising factorials

Definition 2.2 (Rising factorials). *For integers n, k*

$$n^{(k)} = \begin{cases} 0, & \text{if } k < 0, \\ 1, & \text{if } k = 0, \\ \prod_{j=0}^{k-1} (n + j), & \text{if } k > 0. \end{cases}$$

We encourage the audience to read J. F. Steffensen's work on the definition of generalized factorials [?].

Lemma 2.3 (Forward Newton's formula). *Let $f: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ be a function, and let $t \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then, for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$,*

$$f(n) = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{(n-t)^{(k)}}{k!} \Delta^k f(t) = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \binom{n-t}{k} \Delta^k f(t),$$

where the k -th forward difference $\Delta^k f(t)$ of f evaluated at t is defined by

$$\Delta^k f(t) = \sum_{j=0}^k (-1)^{k-j} \binom{k}{j} f(t+j).$$

Proof. By [2, section 2, eq. (19)], and by identity $\frac{(n-t)^{(k)}}{k!} = \binom{n-t}{k}$. □

Lemma 2.4 (Forward Newton's formula for powers). *For non-negative integers n, m , and an arbitrary integer t*

$$n^m = \sum_{k=0}^m \binom{n-t}{k} \Delta^k t^m.$$

Proof. Special case of Lemma (2.3) for powers. □

Lemma 2.5 (Generalized hockey-stick identity). *For arbitrary integers a, b and j ,*

$$\sum_{k=a}^b \binom{k}{j} = \binom{b+1}{j+1} - \binom{a}{j+1}.$$

Proof. We have, $\sum_{k=a}^b \binom{k}{j} = \binom{a}{j} + \binom{a+1}{j} + \cdots + \binom{b}{j} = \left(\sum_{k=0}^b \binom{k}{j} \right) - \left(\sum_{k=0}^{a-1} \binom{k}{j} \right)$. By hockey-stick identity $\sum_{k=0}^n \binom{k}{j} = \binom{n+1}{j+1}$ yields,

$$\sum_{k=a}^b \binom{k}{j} = \left(\sum_{k=0}^b \binom{k}{j} \right) - \left(\sum_{k=0}^{a-1} \binom{k}{j} \right) = \binom{b+1}{j+1} - \binom{a}{j+1}.$$

This completes the proof. □

Lemma 2.6 (Forward hockey-stick identity). *For integer $n \geq 1$, and arbitrary integers t, k, r*

$$\sum_{j=1}^n \binom{j-t+r}{k+r} = \binom{n-t+r+1}{k+r+1} - \binom{1-t+r}{k+r+1}.$$

Proof. By setting $a = 1 - t + r$, and $b = n - t + 1$ into Lemma (2.5). □

Lemma 2.7 (Multifold sums of zero powers). *For non-negative integers r, n*

$$\Sigma^r n^0 = \binom{r+n-1}{r}.$$

Proof.

- (1) Let $r = 0$, then we have $\Sigma^0 n^0 = 1$, by definition (2.1).
- (2) Let $r = 1$, then we have $\Sigma^1 n^0 = \sum_{k=1}^n 1 = \binom{n}{1}$.
- (3) Let $r = 2$, then we have $\Sigma^2 n^0 = \sum_{k=1}^n \binom{k}{1} = \binom{n+1}{2}$.
- (4) Let $r = 3$, then we have $\Sigma^3 n^0 = \sum_{k=1}^n \binom{k+1}{2} = \binom{n+2}{3}$.
- (5) Similarly, for arbitrary integer r , by hockey-stick identity $\sum_{k=1}^n \binom{k}{r} = \binom{n+1}{r+1}$, yields

$$\Sigma^r n^0 = \sum_{k=1}^n \Sigma^{r-1} k^0 = \sum_{k=1}^n \binom{k+r-2}{r-1} = \binom{r+n-1}{r}.$$

This completes the proof. $\square$

Lemma 2.8 (Upper Binomial negation). *For integers n, k*

$$\binom{-n}{k} = (-1)^k \binom{k+n-1}{k}$$

Proof. See [3, p. 164, eq. (5.14)]. $\square$

Convention 2.9. *For all x*

$$x^0 = 1.$$

Donald Knuth give extensive discussion on the convention $x^0 = 1$ for all x , including zero, in Concrete Mathematics [3, p. 162], and in [4].

3. MAIN RESULTS

We start our discussion from Lemma (2.4), which yields forward Newton's interpolation formula for powers. For example,

$$\begin{aligned} n^3 &= 0 \binom{n-0}{0} + 1 \binom{n-0}{1} + 6 \binom{n-0}{2} + 6 \binom{n-0}{3}, \\ n^3 &= 1 \binom{n-1}{0} + 7 \binom{n-1}{1} + 12 \binom{n-1}{2} + 6 \binom{n-1}{3}, \\ n^3 &= 8 \binom{n-2}{0} + 19 \binom{n-2}{1} + 18 \binom{n-2}{2} + 6 \binom{n-2}{3}, \\ n^3 &= 27 \binom{n-3}{0} + 37 \binom{n-3}{1} + 24 \binom{n-3}{2} + 6 \binom{n-3}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus, the transition to formula for sums of powers is quite straightforward,

$$\Sigma^1 n^m = \sum_{k=0}^m \left[\sum_{j=1}^n \binom{j-t}{k} \right] \Delta^k t^m.$$

Therefore, by setting $r = 0$ into Lemma (2.6) yields closed form of ordinary sums of powers

Proposition 3.1 (Ordinary sums of powers). *For non-negative integers n, m , and an arbitrary integer t*

$$\Sigma^1 n^m = \sum_{k=0}^m \left[\binom{n-t+1}{k+1} - \binom{1-t}{k+1} \right] \Delta^k t^m.$$

We may see that the basis $\binom{j-t+r}{k+r}$ for repeatedly applied Lemma (2.6) was indeed chosen correctly, because we derived closed form for sums of powers with ease, simply setting parameter for r . For example,

Example 3.2. *For integer $0 \leq t \leq 3$, we have*

$$\begin{aligned}\Sigma^1 n^3 &= 0\left[\binom{n+1}{1} - \binom{1}{1}\right] + 1\left[\binom{n+1}{2} - \binom{1}{2}\right] + 6\left[\binom{n+1}{3} - \binom{1}{3}\right] + 6\left[\binom{n+1}{4} - \binom{1}{4}\right], \\ \Sigma^1 n^3 &= 1\left[\binom{n}{2} - \binom{0}{2}\right] + 7\left[\binom{n}{3} - \binom{0}{3}\right] + 12\left[\binom{n}{4} - \binom{0}{4}\right] + 6\left[\binom{n}{5} - \binom{0}{5}\right], \\ \Sigma^1 n^3 &= 8\left[\binom{n-1}{2} - \binom{-1}{2}\right] + 19\left[\binom{n-1}{3} - \binom{-1}{3}\right] + 18\left[\binom{n-1}{4} - \binom{-1}{4}\right] + 6\left[\binom{n-1}{5} - \binom{-1}{5}\right], \\ \Sigma^1 n^3 &= 27\left[\binom{n-2}{2} - \binom{-2}{2}\right] + 37\left[\binom{n-2}{3} - \binom{-2}{3}\right] + 24\left[\binom{n-2}{4} - \binom{-2}{4}\right] + 6\left[\binom{n-2}{5} - \binom{-2}{5}\right].\end{aligned}$$

From example above, we may observe binomial coefficients of negative upper index, which may look unfamiliar. However, there is no reason to be afraid of, because negative upper index binomial coefficients are completely deterministic, because $\binom{-n}{k} = (-1)^k \binom{k+n-1}{k}$. By setting $t = 0$ into Proposition (3.1) yields one more well-known identity for sums of powers, mentioned in [3, p. 190], and in [5]

Corollary 3.3. *For non-negative integers n, m*

$$\Sigma^1 n^m = \sum_{j=0}^m \binom{n+1}{j+1} \Delta^j 0^m.$$

For example,

Example 3.4. *For non-negative integer n , we have*

$$\begin{aligned}\Sigma^1 n^1 &= 1 \binom{n+1}{1}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^1 &= 0 \binom{n+1}{1} + 1 \binom{n+1}{2}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^2 &= 0 \binom{n+1}{1} + 1 \binom{n+1}{2} + 2 \binom{n+1}{3}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^3 &= 0 \binom{n+1}{1} + 1 \binom{n+1}{2} + 6 \binom{n+1}{3} + 6 \binom{n+1}{4}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^4 &= 0 \binom{n+1}{1} + 1 \binom{n+1}{2} + 14 \binom{n+1}{3} + 36 \binom{n+1}{4} + 24 \binom{n+1}{5}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^5 &= 0 \binom{n+1}{1} + 1 \binom{n+1}{2} + 30 \binom{n+1}{3} + 150 \binom{n+1}{4} + 240 \binom{n+1}{5} + 120 \binom{n+1}{6}.\end{aligned}$$

From the example above, we observe the coefficients $0, 1, 2, 0, 1, 6, 6, 0, 1, 14, 36, 24, \dots$, are defined by Stirling numbers of the second kind $a_k = k! \left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} n \\ k \end{smallmatrix} \right\}$, which is the sequence [A131689](#) in the OEIS [6]. This leads us to the notion, that Stirling numbers of the second kind $\left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} n \\ k \end{smallmatrix} \right\}$ recover naturally from forward Newton's interpolation formula for powers. By setting $t = 1$ into Proposition (3.1), we get another well-known special case

Corollary 3.5. *For non-negative integers n, m ,*

$$\Sigma^1 n^m = \sum_{j=0}^m \binom{n}{j+1} \Delta^j 1^m,$$

mentioned, for instance, in [7]. For example,

Example 3.6. *For non-negative integer n , we have*

$$\begin{aligned}\Sigma^1 n^0 &= 1 \binom{n}{1}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^1 &= 1 \binom{n}{1} + 1 \binom{n}{2}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^2 &= 1 \binom{n}{1} + 3 \binom{n}{2} + 2 \binom{n}{3}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^3 &= 1 \binom{n}{1} + 7 \binom{n}{2} + 12 \binom{n}{3} + 6 \binom{n}{4}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^4 &= 1 \binom{n}{1} + 15 \binom{n}{2} + 50 \binom{n}{3} + 60 \binom{n}{4} + 24 \binom{n}{5}, \\ \Sigma^1 n^5 &= 1 \binom{n}{1} + 31 \binom{n}{2} + 180 \binom{n}{3} + 390 \binom{n}{4} + 360 \binom{n}{5} + 120 \binom{n}{6}.\end{aligned}$$

The coefficients $1, 1, 1, 1, 3, 2, 1, 7, 12, 6, 1, 15, \dots$ is the sequence [A028246](#) in the OEIS [6]. It is interesting to note that the work [7] provide formulas for sums of powers in terms of generalized Stirling numbers of the second kind $\left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} k \\ j \end{smallmatrix} \right\}_r$, that is

Proposition 3.7 (Cereceda (2022)). *For non-negative integers n, k*

$$\Sigma^1 n^k = \sum_{j=0}^k j! \left[\binom{n+1-r}{j+1} + (-1)^j \binom{r+j-1}{j+1} \right] \left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} k \\ j \end{smallmatrix} \right\}_r, \quad (1)$$

And

$$\Sigma^1 n^k = \sum_{j=0}^k j! \left[\binom{n+1+r}{j+1} + \binom{r+1}{j+1} \right] \left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} k \\ j \end{smallmatrix} \right\}_{-r}. \quad (2)$$

Formula (1) is a special case of Proposition (3.1) with setting $t \rightarrow r$, and upper negated binomial coefficient $\binom{1-t}{k+1}$, by using upper negation formula from Lemma (2.8). We may observe that forward finite difference of powers $\Delta^k t^m$ can be expressed in terms of generalized Stirling numbers of the second kind, that is

$$\Delta^k t^m = k! \left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} m \\ k \end{smallmatrix} \right\}_t. \quad (3)$$

This leads us to the observation, that generalized Stirling numbers of the second kind $\left\{ \begin{smallmatrix} n \\ k \end{smallmatrix} \right\}_t$ recover naturally from forward Newton's interpolation formula for powers, evaluated in arbitrary integer t . Now, reviewing Formula (2), we notice that it is a special case of Proposition (3.1) with setting $t \rightarrow -r$, and by using Equation (3). For example, by setting $t = 4$ into Proposition (3.1) yields rather unusual formulas for sums of powers

$$\Sigma^1 n^0 = 1 \left(\binom{n-3}{1} + \binom{3}{1} \right),$$

$$\Sigma^1 n^1 = 4 \left(\binom{n-3}{1} + \binom{3}{1} \right) + 1 \left(\binom{n-3}{2} - \binom{4}{2} \right),$$

$$\Sigma^1 n^2 = 16 \left(\binom{n-3}{1} + \binom{3}{1} \right) + 9 \left(\binom{n-3}{2} - \binom{4}{2} \right) + 2 \left(\binom{n-2}{3} + \binom{5}{3} \right),$$

$$\Sigma^1 n^3 = 64 \left(\binom{n-3}{1} + \binom{3}{1} \right) + 61 \left(\binom{n-3}{2} - \binom{4}{2} \right) + 30 \left(\binom{n-3}{3} + \binom{5}{3} \right) + 6 \left(\binom{n-3}{4} - \binom{6}{4} \right).$$

The coefficients $1, 4, 1, 16, 9, \dots$ is the sequence [A391633](#) in the OEIS [6].

4. STIRLING FORM

5. EULERIAN FORM

6. BACKWARD DIFFERENCE FORM

7. CENTRAL DIFFERENCE FORM

8. CONCLUSIONS

9. ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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10. MATHEMATICA

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